



KID STUFF: A girl gets laser hair reduction at Kaya Skin Clinic, Mumbai

As if overzealous parents were not enough, arriviste starlets proudly crediting their success to a surgical makeover has made cosmetic surgery a fashion statement. The early onset of adulthood in children is not only the result of increased exposure to media, medical practitioners believe children are maturing faster even genetically. Dr Pai says: "By 16 a girl is grown up, unlike boys who take longer. Even the menstrual cycle is now setting in at 10 years, unlike a few years ago when puberty in females set in at 13 years." Be it shopping for their own clothes at four or opting for cosmetic surgery at 13, children are taking their own decisions today. Says Bidappa, who has a 16-year-old daughter of his own: "Kids grow up too early, are more aware and

have more money to spend. This is the disease of any affluent society and we can't avoid it." Dr Rashmi Taneja, plastic surgeon and consultant, Sir Gangaram Hospital, Delhi, recalls her first minor patient, a 15-year-old girl, who came with her parents for a liposuction as she was overweight. The hospital turned down the demand.

Interestingly, the more money the

parents have, the more impossible is the demand, claim doctors. Most often these teenagers end up in clinics with their mothers, with a photograph of their favourite film stars asking for a certain type of a nose or chin. Says Dr Milind Wagh, cosmetic surgeon at Hiranandani Hospital in Mumbai: "Children normally come with their mothers as they are more malleable. Today's society is driven by what children want."

To many young minds, item girl Rakhi Sawant's confessions on a talk show about her implants has become an inspiration of sorts. Says Sawant: "When I first stepped into my cosmetic surgeon's clinic to get breast implants and my lips pumped up, I was shocked to see girls as young as 17 and 18 waiting to get implants. These surgeries are a boon to young girls who want to be like me."

"The middle classes are willing to shell out money for these treatments to pursue glamorous careers."

DR RASHMI TANEJA, PLASTIC SURGEON